In retrospect, it is also worth noting that when the Eurozone sought direct bilateral bailouts to help manage its sovereign debt crisis, the BRICS insisted on helping through the existing institutional structure, the IMF, instead of a European special-purpose vehicle that would allow European debtors more flexibility, avoiding the hard conditionality and shame of an IMF program. Indian, Russian, and Brazilian officials ruled out lending to the Eurozone except through the IMF. Nonetheless, the IMF was prepared to extend "flexible credit lines," with few conditions, to select countries like Spain and Italy that sought rebranding. However, India and other BRICS publicly complained about double standards by the IMF, which give Eurozone countries easier conditions without a stigma attached.[48]

The BRICS Seek Leadership Positions

Since the founding of the IMF and World Bank, the IMF managing director always has been a Western European, and the president of the World Bank an American,[49] although the numbers of very senior staff from the BRICS and other emerging economies at these organizations have increased notably in the last 15 years. Another dimension of the BRICS' influence within the major international financial institutions has been their desire to see prominent non-Western economists have the opportunity to head these institutions.[50] In April 2011, the BRICS affirmed their interest in ending the *de facto* Western monopoly on appointing the heads of the two institutions. When IMF Managing Director Dominique Strauss-Kahn resigned suddenly in May, they had an unexpectedly early opportunity to unite around a single candidate. The BRICS members issued a statement on May 24, 2011, reiterating their collective desire that the selection should be fair and based on merit rather than on the convention of the IMF managing director always coming from Europe.[51]

The announced candidates included Stanley Fischer, former IMF deputy managing director and a dual U.S. and Israeli citizen, who had excellent technical qualifications and many supporters in Africa and the developing world, but not the nationality profile that the BRICS or many other countries hoped to promote. Russia supported National Bank of Kazakhstan Chair Grigorii Marchenko, whose candidacy Finance Minister Aleksei Kudrin called "a positive thing," while noting that other BRICS members "already have their candidates and we shall weigh them up too."[52] Although the Russian media were generally skeptical that a developing country's candidate